The Runaway Train

Ursula West

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Chapter One

"Toot!" said the slow train as it pulled into the station.

Every day it went round the smoky city.

Every day was just the same.

[Image: 1 Smokey city.png]

"One day," he said to himself, "I am going to have a holiday."

Then, when nobody was looking, he took a different turning and off he went.

"Hey, wait for me!" said the driver, but the train didn't stop.

"Hey, wait for me!" said the guard, but the train didn't stop.

[Image: 2 Big buildings.png]

On and on he went, chugging past the grey houses and the dirty old buildings.

"Country, here I come!" he hooted, and on and on he went.

"Where are we going?" said the passengers. "What can be going on?" they all said.

They looked out of the windows as they left the city far behind.

[Image: 3 Countryside.png]

First, they saw lots of trees and rivers, then they saw cows standing in the fields.

"This is fun", said one little boy. But his mum was a bit puzzled.

Toot, toot, said the train and on and on he went.

Suddenly, he saw the loveliest thing he had ever seen. Lots and lots of water, in fact, so much water that he couldn't see to the other side.

"The sea! The Sea!" shouted the little boy and jumped up and down with excitement.

[Image: 4 Seaside.png]

The runaway train had found his place at last.

"This is where I'll stop," he said and came to a halt just beside a beautiful golden beach.

He let out a long, slow hiss of steam and settled down to enjoy a nice, quiet day. "Yes", he said to himself, "this is the place for me."

. . .

All the passengers simply did not know what to think. They sat for a long time, wondering what to do.

Eventually the little boy said, "come on mum, let's go out and play in the sand."

Just then, they heard footsteps, and a guard came panting and puffing along the track.

"Everybody out!" he shouted. "Sorry about this," he said. "We will take you all back this evening, but I'm afraid we don't have many trains down here and we just can't get this one to move again."

Bit by bit, everybody was helped out and given nice hot cups of tea at the nearby station.

As far as the little boy was concerned, he was not going to wait around in a draughty old station. In two minutes he and his mum were off down to the beach.

The sand was just great and, to his delight, he found an old spade and bucket.

"Woopee!" he shouted and got to work.

[Image: 6 Sandpie Spade.png]

The other passengers heard all the noise and peered out of the windows.

"Oh look at that, Johnny! Do you want to join him?"

Soon Johnny, Bertha, Alice, Luke and a whole bunch of mums and dads were down there on the beach, dipping their toes in the water, helping their kids to gather shells and forgetting about the old smokey city.

What a lovely day they had.

In fact, it was such a lovely day that they asked the guard when this train would be returning here.

"Well," said the guard, "they closed this line to passenger trains a few years ago. Just freight trains come here now."

By this time, many of the passengers were crowding around the guard and heard what he said.

They all looked very sad and unhappy about this. "We want to come back here!" they all started saying.

"Well, you will all have to send in a letter to this address," he said, writing it down on a card "and who knows, if they think many people want to come here again, they might just change their mind."

That was that! They went back home and wrote lots of letters saying that they wanted their local beach back again.

It worked! A few months later, on a bright sunny afternoon, all the passengers gathered on a platform and boarded the runaway train, which puffed happily back to the golden beach.

[Image: 5 Boy Sandcastle.png]

When it stopped at the station, everyone poured out of the train. There were grown-ups with deckchairs and picnics and, of course, lots of kids clutching buckets and spades. Bit by bit, they all toddled off the train and off they went to enjoy another great day at the beach.

Toot, Toot .....

What a clever train!

Chapter 2

The Runaway Train

A Bedtime Story

"Toot!" said the slow train as it pulled into the station.

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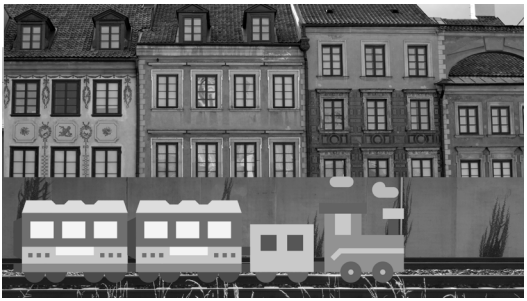

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